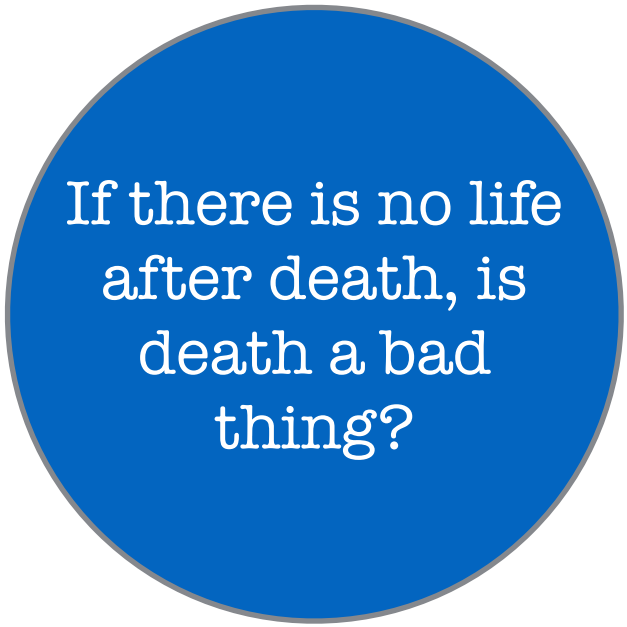


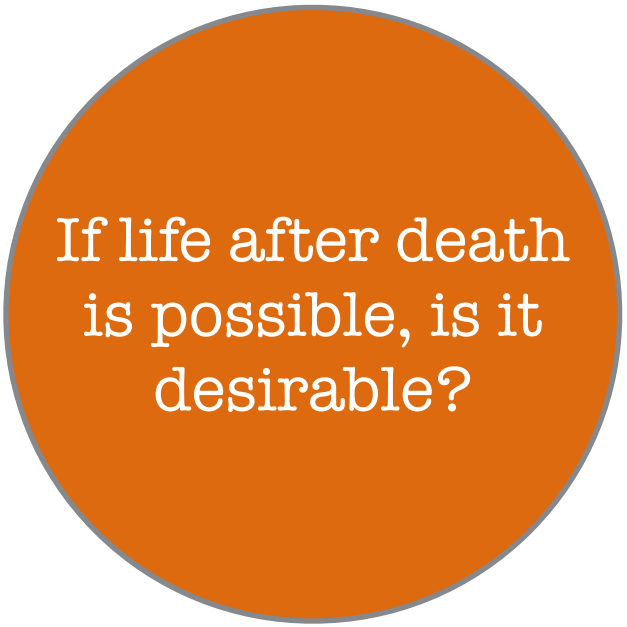




If there is no life  
after death, is  
death a bad  
thing?



Is there life after  
death?

A large orange circle with a thin grey border, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "If life after death is possible, is it desirable?" is written in white, serif font, arranged in three lines.

If life after death  
is possible, is it  
desirable?

When we were discussing the nature of persons, we discussed the question of whether life after death is possible. Life after death seems pretty clear possible on proponent of soul survival or psychological views; matters are trickier if materialism about persons is true, but even here there is room to believe in the possibility of life after death.

But of course even if life after death is possible, that doesn't tell us whether or not there is life after death. Let's turn to that question now.

There are a number of arguments for and against life after death that I'll mention only briefly and then set aside.

The first is what might be called the **argument from religion**. There are as many versions of this argument as there are religions; here is one



1. Christianity is true.

2. If Christianity is true, there is life after death.

---

C. There is life after death.

The second argument I am going to mention and then set aside is the

argument from near death experiences.

Many people who come very close to death report similar kinds of experiences — a feeling of looking down at one's body, of feeling disembodied, of moving towards a light. One might argue from these experiences as follows:

1. People have near death experiences.
  2. If there were no life after death, people would not have near death experiences..
- 

C. There is life after death.

I am going to look at two philosophical arguments on this topic — one for the existence of life after death, and the other against it.

It is worth noting that this is an argument for life after death, but cannot in any obvious way (unlike the argument from religion) be turned into an argument for immortality.

The first argument has its origins in Plato's *Phaedo*. This is a dialogue which takes place between Socrates and his friends, after Socrates has been sentenced to death for corrupting the youth of Athens.

Socrates is unworried, explaining to his friends that death is nothing to be afraid of; death is just the death of the body, and not the death of him.



He gives a few arguments in favor of this view; the most influential is contained in the following passage:

‘We ought, I think,’ said Socrates, ‘to ask ourselves this: What sort of thing is it that would naturally suffer the fate of being dispersed? For what sort of thing should we fear this fate, and for what should we not? When we have answered this, we should next consider to which class the soul belongs; and then we shall know whether to feel confidence or fear about the fate of our souls.’

‘Quite true.’

‘Would you not expect a composite object or a natural compound to be liable to break up where it was put together? and ought not anything which is really in-composite to be the one thing of all others which is not affected in this way?’

Socrates begins by asking what sorts of things can be 'dispersed.' He considers two categories of things: composite things, which have parts, and incomposite things, which are simple and have no parts.

It seems clear that composite things can be dispersed, whereas simple things cannot.

Being dispersed, after all, is just a matter of having your parts taken out of connection with each other, and simple things have no parts.

But, one might think, this shows that only composite things can be destroyed; for how can you destroy something other than by breaking it up into its parts?

The key question, then, is: are we complex, or simple?

Plato was, like Descartes, a proponent of soul survival — he held that we are immaterial souls. If we assume this proponent of soul survival view, then the question is whether immaterial souls are composite or simple.

We can then give the following argument for immortality:



1. Persons are immaterial souls.
2. All immaterial things are simple.
3. Only composite things can be destroyed.
4. Immaterial souls cannot be destroyed. (2,3)

-----

C. Persons cannot be destroyed. (1,4)

We've already considered defenses of the first premise. Obviously, materialists and psychological theorists who reject those defenses are unlikely to be persuaded by this argument. But should proponents of soul survival be convinced by it?

One might question either premise (2) or premise (3).

ARGUMENT FROM THE SIMPLICITY OF THE SOUL

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A reasonable argument can be made that immaterial souls are simple rather than composite. For, arguably, we have no grip on what it would take for an immaterial thing — which is not extended in space — to have parts.

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